

State seeks stricter school timeout rules

Would disallow use of locked, confined space

By Mandy McLaren
GLOBE STAFF

Massachusetts education officials Tuesday moved to limit disciplinary measures in schools involving the use of so-called timeout rooms, which are most often used to subdue students with disabilities.

The new proposed regulations attempt to further clarify the distinction between a timeout, which is voluntary and allowed under state law, and seclusion, which is involuntary and prohibited. Schools would be expressly prohibited from using timeouts to place a student in a locked confined space, but under certain emergency situations would be able to use a form of seclusion in a secure room.

Some schools in the state have been deploying what appears to be seclusion but calling it a timeout, a 2024 Globe investigation found.

Interim Massachusetts Education Commissioner Russell Johnston presented the proposed regulations to the Board of Elementary and Secondary Education at the panel's Tuesday morning meeting. The 11-member board voted unanimously to move forward with the proposal; the regulations will now be posted for public comment before a final vote in June.

If ultimately approved, the new regulations would address longstanding concerns among parents of special education students and advocates about timeout rooms in schools — namely, they are used discriminatorily against students with disabilities, inflicting lasting trauma.

“There are many (schools) **TIMEOUT ROOMS, Page A10**

‘It’s just always there . . . the empty seat at the table.’

BARBARA BOWER, *whose husband, bicyclist John Corcoran, was killed in a crash*

Charges sought in fatal bike crash

Cyclist killed in Cambridge six months ago

By Spencer Buell and Shannon Larson
GLOBE STAFF

Prosecutors said Tuesday that they are seeking charges against the driver of a vehicle that fatally struck a 62-year-old cyclist in Cambridge last fall, triggering protests from local cyclists and safety improvements along Memorial Drive where the incident occurred.

An application for a criminal complaint has been filed, said Meghan Kelly, spokesperson for the Middlesex district attorney's office. A clerk magistrate will hold a hearing to determine whether there is probable cause to issue charges.

John Corcoran, a Newton

father of two, was riding his bike near the Boston University DeWolfe Boathouse around rush hour on a Monday evening last September, in an area that cyclists had flagged for years as potentially dangerous, arguing it puts riders and pedestrians perilously close to oncoming traffic.

Police at the time said the driver lost control of his vehicle and struck Corcoran. The driver, who has yet to be identified, was described at the time as a man in his 20s. Corcoran, who worked at an investment management company in Boston, was pronounced dead at Massachusetts General Hospital, authorities said.

The update from the district attorney, which did not include the specific charges prosecutors are seeking, followed a probe led by the Massachusetts State Police Collision Analysis and Reconstruction **CORCORAN, Page A10**



Matthew J. Lee/Globe Staff

Barbara Bower hugged her daughter near the ghost bike memorial for Bower's husband, John Corcoran.

VINES BY THE YARD



Jessica Rinaldi/Globe Staff

Lindsay Grimes (top right), a horticulturist at the Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum, handed down a 20-foot vine of nasturtiums to other horticulturists as they moved the flowers from a South Shore greenhouse to the Boston museum on Tuesday. Each year, the courtyard at the Gardner Museum is draped with the flowering vines, a tradition started by Isabella Stewart Gardner herself to mark the arrival of spring. **B2.**

Dual citizenship? Yes please, they say.

Growing number of Americans are seeking ways to expand their options

By Christopher Muther
GLOBE STAFF

Tim Hennigan and Peter Atlas are tired of the political divisiveness, unstable international relations, and Teslas parked in front of the White House. Most of all, they are fed up with President Trump. The Charlestown couple is in the final stages of obtaining Irish citizenship and recently moved to their new home in Ireland, where they will wait out the current administration.

“This is not just four years of a president that we don't happen to like,” Hennigan said. “This is a different regime, and it's

time to leave. For years, I saw progress with race equality, women's equality, and gay equality. Now, I think maybe we've already lived through the pinnacle of equality, at least in this country.”

Atlas, a retired school teacher, and Hennigan, a travel adviser who can work remotely, are concerned about their rights as a gay married couple. Despite recently completing a 20-month renovation of their Boston home, they have decided to uproot.

The couple are among the growing number of Americans seeking dual citizenship through ancestry or golden visa programs. Rules vary by country, but a golden visa al-

lows individuals to qualify for residency or citizenship in exchange for an investment in real estate. They obtained ancestry through Hennigan's Irish roots. Google searches in the United States for dual citizenship hit a five-year high the week of the November presidential election and grew again the week of the inauguration. However, the number of those taking the next step has been more telling than quick Google searches.

Because obtaining dual citizenship can be time-consuming and expensive, it's been primarily limited to people with free time or **CITIZENSHIP, Page A6**

Colleges brace as GOP eyes raising tax on endowments

Schools use funds for operating budget, financial aid offers

By Hilary Burns
GLOBE STAFF

Top colleges and universities across the nation are bracing for a sharp increase in the tax rate they pay on investment returns as Republicans in Congress mull several proposals to target large endowments. This proposed reform could be a devastating blow to the nation's most prestigious schools, including at least a dozen of New England's storied campuses with large endowments.

Republicans are considering increases to the university endowment tax to help reduce the national deficit and as a potential lever to force universities to comply

with the Trump administration's priorities. The nation's wealthiest private colleges and universities currently pay an excise tax of 1.4 percent on endowment investment returns, a levy established during President Trump's first term despite heavy pushback from universities.

“If institutions choose to sit on a \$1 billion, or a \$10 billion, or a \$20 billion endowment while having students borrow money from taxpayers, and then celebrate when the students don't repay that — it'd be nice to see those institutions actually putting more skin in the game,” said Rick Hess, director of education policy studies at the right-leaning American Enterprise Institute in Washington, D.C.

Top universities were able to absorb the 1.4 percent tax without much disruption, but higher education watchers say further increases would be disastrous for **ENDOWMENTS, Page A7**

Cuts at EPA protested
Dozens of federal EPA workers marched near Post Office Square to protest the plans to dramatically slash the federal organization by 65 percent. **B3.**

Trump downplays leak
The president characterized an extraordinary security breach as a minor transgression and stood by his national security adviser. **A2.**

Many federal workers stay the course amid firings

See dedication to serve as way to defy Trump

By Katie Johnston and Chris Serres
GLOBE STAFF

When 16 employees were fired from the Department of Agriculture's Boston office last month, it happened so quickly that crucial meetings were missed and half-finished projects had to be restarted — a result of downsizing by the Department of Government Efficiency.

But despite heavier workloads and the threat of more layoffs on the horizon, the employees who remained — and others around the federal workforce facing similar reductions — say they're still dedicated to their jobs.

“The goal in trying to traumatize us is to make us leave,” said Ellen Mei, 29, who works in Food and Nutrition Service. “By staying, we're saying we don't care what you do, we're going to provide the services that we're duty-bound to provide.”

More than 30,000 federal employees have been fired in the first two months of President Trump's administration, and thousands more are on the chopping block as DOGE **FEDERAL WORKERS, Page A6**

Simmons University and Swedish building giant Skanska have unveiled designs for the long-planned overhaul of Simmons' campus. **B5.**

From a dollars and cents perspective, the decision to enter the world of professional figure skating is kind of nuts. **C1.**

Unclear on the concept



Wednesday: Cloudy, showers. High: 45-50. Low: 32-37.

Thursday: Some sun, breezy. High: 47-52. Low: 35-40.

Comics and Weather, **G6-7.**

Obituaries, **C9.**



A chicken on every plot

With egg prices — and anxiety — high, some see a solution in backyard chickens, but nothing is perfect. **G1.**